

Higher Education Incentive Policy 2024

FOCUS
UTTAR PRADESH



Yogi Adityanath

Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

Uttar Pradesh is taking a more deliberate approach to the growth of higher education, looking beyond the established cities where universities have traditionally been concentrated. The Higher Education Incentive Policy 2024



Narendra Modi

Prime Minister of India

seeks to encourage private universities, multidisciplinary institutions and research centres to establish themselves in districts where higher education infrastructure remains limited. The ambition is not simply to create more seats.

Uttar Pradesh is offering up to 100% stamp duty exemption, capital subsidies of up to ₹100 crore for top-ranked national or foreign institutions, and relaxed land norms to establish universities in underserved and aspirational districts. Aligned with NEP guidelines, the policy seeks to expand access, improve GER and promote multidisciplinary research and quality education. The state's private university count has risen to 56, with institutions such as Vidya University (Meerut), KD University (Mathura), Maharishi Mahesh Yogi Ramayan University (Ayodhya) and Sardar Patel Apex University (Mirzapur).

Creating New Centres of Opportunity

The geographical focus of the policy gives this investment strategy a wider development dimension. Special attention is being given to 40 unserved districts and eight aspirational districts identified by NITI Aayog. The significance goes beyond where a campus is located. A strong university in a district with limited higher education infrastructure can become an institutional anchor, expanding access while creating demand for skilled talent, employment, research and supporting services.

Policy at a Glance

40 unserved districts identified for higher education expansion

8 NITI Aayog-designated aspirational districts given special focus

Incentives aimed at encouraging private universities, MERUs and research institutions

Special provisions to attract leading foreign universities and top-ranked Indian institutions

Financial and land-related support designed to encourage long-term institutional investment

Focus on access, quality, research, talent retention and regional development



Combining Access with Quality

The policy is not focused only on expanding the number of institutions. It also seeks to raise the quality and profile of Uttar Pradesh's higher education landscape by encouraging recognised institutions to establish a presence in the state. The focus on leading foreign universities and India's top-ranked institutions reflects an effort to bring stronger academic standards, specialised programmes and research capabilities into the state. Their presence could also create closer links between higher education, industry and emerging sectors of the economy. This gives the policy a dual ambition: wider access and stronger quality. Students outside established education centres could gain access to institutions and programmes better aligned with evolving professional and technological opportunities.

A Broader Development Strategy

The larger significance of the Higher Education Incentive Policy 2024 lies in its attempt to change where knowledge and opportunity are created across Uttar Pradesh. Instead of allowing higher education infrastructure to follow existing patterns of investment, the state is using policy support to encourage new academic centres in regions where they could have a wider social and economic impact. If these institutions develop successfully, they could strengthen local talent markets, support research and innovation, and create stronger reasons for young people to study and build careers within the state. The policy is therefore not simply about building more universities. It is about creating new centres of learning that can contribute to the long-term development of their regions.